



CANOPY



**HORNBILLS** use their long bill to collect fruit growing on the high branches in seasonal forest. In tropical rain forest, toucans feed in the same way.



**FOR STICK INSECTS** and leaf insects, highly developed camouflage is the key to survival in seasonal forest.

**FRUIT BATS**, the world's largest bats, are almost all found in tropical forest habitats.



**THE ATLAS MOTH** is found in seasonal forest, as are many of the world's other large, winged insects.

UNDERSTORY



**FOREST CATS** make up more than half of the world's cat species. The tiger is the largest and one of the most endangered.



**SNAKES** in seasonal forest include species that hunt on the ground, and those that climb trees to search for prey.

FOREST FLOOR

## Seasonal (monsoon) forest

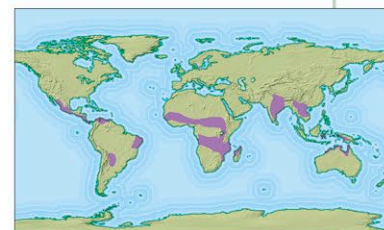
Unlike rain forest, where the climate is very stable, seasonal forest grows where rainfall is concentrated into a wet, or rainy season, which is known as a monsoon. Up to 8¼ft (2.5m) of rain can fall in just 3 months—as much as some tropical rain forests receive throughout the whole year. As a consequence, seasonal forest is not as tall as tropical rain forest and, typically, the canopy is more open and extends farther toward the forest floor.

Immediately after the monsoon, seasonal forest is lush and green; but in the long dry season that follows, many of the trees shed their leaves, and the piercing sunlight is able to reach

through the bare branches to the ground. Some seasonal forest trees are unusual in that they flower

and fruit after losing their leaves. Where this happens, birds, insects, and mammals congregate in large numbers to feed. In the rainy season, the forest's animals are well hidden by the foliage; once the leaves have fallen, they become much easier to find.

Despite the yearly cycle of deluge and drought, the animal life of seasonal forest is some of the most numerous and varied in the world. In southern Asia, which has the largest area of this type of forest, the habitat supports elephants, monkeys, leopards, and also tigers. In Asia's seasonal forests, there are some spectacular birds, including giant hornbills, and some of the world's largest snakes. In Africa, seasonal forests abound with browsing antelopes while, in Central America, they are inhabited by pumas, coatis, and white-tailed deer. Most of these animals breed during the wet season, when they can take advantage of the abundant supply of fresh leaves.



**SEASONAL FOREST** grows on either side of the equator. The dry season lasts longer the farther the region is from the equator.

## DEFORESTATION

The world's tropical forests are being cleared at a rate unparalleled in human history. About half the original cover has been destroyed in the last 50 years, reducing the amount of carbon locked up in trees, which in turn boosts climate change. In many tropical countries, large areas of forest now have legal protection, but with growing pressure for farmland and lumber, controls are often difficult to enforce.

Tropical deforestation is also fueled by the international demand for commodities such as cocoa, rubber, and palm oil—an ingredient of biofuels, soap, and many processed foods. These are often grown in plantations on formerly forested land.



### FORMER FOREST

Tropical forest clearance follows the pattern set in forests in other parts of the world, but its impact on plants and animals is greater because there are so many species at stake.